

Boundary spanning activity as a function of the small business owner's decision style

James D. Brodzinski
Salisbury State University

Robert F. Scherer
Wright State University

Frank A. Wiebe
University of Mississippi

ABSTRACT

This study investigated the effects of small business owner decision styles on the search for external assistance information, community information, and competitor information. Results confirmed the existence of decision style differences in selection of boundary spanning activities. A conclusion is drawn that small business owners use preferred sources for gathering information related to business operations, but need to utilize additional sources to ensure a comprehensive boundary spanning role. Ways to enhance boundary spanning activities are provided.

INTRODUCTION

Obtaining information from sources external to the small business organization has been linked to both the survival and profitability of the firm. Dollinger, for example, found that although the importance of any one source of environmental contact made by the small business owner was not singularly related to performance, the amount of time the owner spent engaged in external contacts was positively related to sales, net income, and an index of profitability (10, 11). Other investigations aimed at describing the networks developed by entrepreneurs have shown that these individuals seek contacts to improve personal competencies and performance of the firm (4, 5, 7, 8, 9). However, the types of information sought by the small business owner may be a function of the owner's fit with and preferred method of interacting with the external environment (12, 18, 23).

Aldrich and Zimmer have suggested that networks established by the small business owner serve the functions of information passage, exchange of content, and development of social relationships based upon expectations of the networking participants (2). Strength of the linkage between two or more individuals depends to a great extent on the level, frequency, and reciprocity offered by the relationship. These formally and informally established networks with external constituencies provide the impetus for exploiting opportunities which may benefit the small business organization. Thus, small business owners with high performance firms will have ties to people who provide timely information and needed resources (8).

THE FUNCTION OF BOUNDARY SPANNING ACTIVITIES

In order for organizations to monitor changes in the environment and to orchestrate a fit between these changes and the business, individuals perform a variety of boundary spanning activities (BSA) which afford decision makers the opportunity to assess and gauge the effects of these changes on the organization (16). Boundary spanners are defined as individuals who are at the interfaces of the organization or the boundary between the organization and its environment. The purposes of BSA performed by these individuals are to filter, transact, buffer, represent, and protect the organization (1).

In large organizations employees fill specific boundary spanning roles to keep the organization informed. These positions are familiar ones such as salesperson, customer service representative, lobbyist, and purchasing agent, for example. However, in smaller organizations, it is unlikely that the resources are available to support such specific job descriptions and the employment of specialists in each boundary spanning area. Therefore, many times it is the owner who takes a majority of the responsibility for interfacing with external constituencies and forming network contacts at organizational boundaries (10, 11).

The small business owner acquires information from the environment and then translates that information into opportunities for the organization. Johnson and Kuehn found that a typical owner/manager spends more than two hours per day in external contact activity (13). Furthermore, the quality, clarity, and time span for gathering information about the environment are all important considerations for the small business owner.

Although the criteria for assessing environmental information has been investigated, the importance of types of specific information to small business owners is not clear. Researchers in the area of organizational decision making have proposed that when individuals are confronted with complex problems requiring synthesis of much information, an incremental search for and evaluation of information is efficient (17). Additionally, Simon has observed that a decision maker is bounded by values, personality, and collective experiences in gathering and processing information (21). Given these limitations on the ability of an individual to process and act on environmental information, it is reasonable that a small business owner, with limited resources to spend on acquisition and interpretation of environmental information, would develop only certain information networks at organizational boundaries.

DECISION STYLE AS A DETERMINANT OF BSA

Human information processing concerns the cognitive/affective and analytic/intuitive aspects of decision making and problem solving (22). Recently, there has been an interest among researchers in examining the effects of decision style on strategy formulation, organizational effectiveness, and boundary spanning (3, 12, 19, 20). The approach centers around classification of decision makers on two dimensions resulting in a definition of one's primary decision style (14).

An initial classification is made on the individual's method of gathering or perceiving information (15). This is labeled as either a sensation (S) or intuition (N) mode. A sensing individual prefers to acquire information that deals with hard facts and specifics while an intuitive person seeks information that describes possibilities and is more qualitative and subjective. Processing the obtained information is performed through either a thinking (T) or feeling (F) mode. Use of a thinking mode focuses on logical evaluation and formal reasoning, and use of a feeling mode revolves around the effects of the decision on the stakes of the individuals involved. From these two dimensions four basic decision styles are defined as ST, NT, SF, and NF.

This human information processing approach to understanding decision making offers an avenue to explain and predict the specific types of environmental contacts the small business owner will cultivate and the types of information sought from the environment with limited resources for BSA (see Table 1). The ST decision maker prefers factual data and has an impersonal or analytical tendency. An NT decision maker deals with general concepts and is concerned more with broad issues and emphasizes the conceptual. The NF type is characterized by broad concerns of a social nature and is interested in idealistic concepts. The fourth type, SE, is concerned with human relations and with facts.

Table 1. Typology of Decision Styles

		Sensate (S)	Intuitive (N)
Preferred Method of Information Processing	Thinking (T)	SYSTEMATIC (ST)	SPECULATIVE (NT)
		<i>Information:</i> Quantitative measures	<i>Information:</i> Future possibilities
		<i>Guarantee:</i> Statistical significance	<i>Guarantee:</i> Assumptions and probabilities
		<i>Decision Tools:</i> Cost-benefit analysis and evaluation research	<i>Decision Tools:</i> Decision trees; sensitivity analysis
	Feeling (F)	JUDICIAL (SF)	HEURISTIC (NF)
		<i>Information:</i> Current conditions or events	<i>Information:</i> Current possibilities
		<i>Guarantee:</i> Acceptance by interested parties	<i>Guarantee:</i> Experience and judgment
		<i>Decision Tools:</i> Decision groups	<i>Decision Tools:</i> Mutual adjustment

Source: P. C. Nutt, "Decision Style and Its Impact on Managers and Management," *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 29 (1986), 341-66.

Applying this typology, the decision makers should seek out information through BSA which are congruent with their primary decision style. Specifically, this means that the small business owner will expend time gathering, processing, and acting on information which is the most compatible with his/her style. If this proposition is supported, there would be implications for providing small business owners with assistance in developing competencies in selecting and processing other types of environmental information and establishing networks to enhance the fit between organization and environment. The objective of the current study was to determine if the primary decision style of the small business owner affects the type of BSA engaged in by the owner. The following hypothesis was tested: H₁—The environmental contacts developed through the boundary spanning activities of the small business owner will vary as a function of decision style.

METHODS

Sample

Subjects in this study were 57 (29 male and 28 female) small business owners operating in a southeastern state. For this sample the term small business was used to identify owners whose firms employed less than one hundred people and had annual gross sales of less than one million dollars. Business types were primarily retail (27.5%) and service (19.6%), with the rest being classified as manufacturing, construction, and wholesale. These subjects were generally middle-aged (40-49 years of age) and relatively well educated. Approximately 47% of the participants had obtained at least some graduate education.

Measures

Boundary Spanning Items. To determine the number of contacts with individuals in the external environment, as a gauge of BSA, subjects were asked to record the number of face-to-face, written, and telephone contacts they had during a one-week period with (1) bankers, lawyers, accountants; (2) trade and business associations; (3) regulatory agency officials; (4) stockholders; (5) private consultants; (6) civic and social organizations; and (7) competitors (see Table 2 for the mean and percentage of total contacts for the entire sample). The items chosen to measure BSA were derived from Dollinger's study of small business owners (10, 11). Composite measures were constructed by summing the number of face-to-face, written, and telephone contacts for each BSA category.

Table 2. Descriptive Statistics for Boundary Spanning Items

TOTAL SAMPLE			
Item		Mean	% of Total Contacts
Business and Trade Associations		6.33	23
Regulatory Agencies		4.26	15
Private Consultants		1.79	6
Bankers, Lawyers, Accountants		3.33	12
Civic Organizations		8.40	30
Stockholders		1.11	4
Competitors		2.77	10
COMPOSITE VARIABLES BY GROUP			
Decision Style	N	Variable	% Total Contacts by Group
SF	20	External Assistance Information ^a	27
		Community Assistance Information ^b	67
		Competitor Information ^c	6
ST	7	External Assistance Information	34
		Community Assistance Information	28
		Competitor Information	38
NF	24	External Assistance Information	48
		Community Assistance Information	37
		Competitor Information	15
NT	6	External Assistance Information	89
		Community Assistance Information	6
		Competitor Information	5

^aBusiness and Trade Associations; Regulatory Agencies; Private Consultants; Bankers, Lawyers, Accountants.
^bStockholders and Civic Organizations.
^cCompetitors.

Decision Style. In this study decision style was operationalized using a short-form version of a Type Indicator which has been used in past small business research (6). Respondents evaluate eight sets of two questions each to identify information gathering style and eight sets of two questions each to identify information processing style. From each two-question set, the respondent chooses the statement which is most representative of individual behavior. The selected statements are summed and used to classify a respondent into a primary decision style category based upon the highest scores for the information gathering and processing dimensions. This results in identification of either ST, SF, NT, or NF as a primary decision style.

Design and Analytic Strategy

Dimensionality and Reliability. The BSA items were subjected to a principal components factor analysis with varimax rotation to determine if they could be combined in a conceptually meaningful way. Three factors were extracted with eigenvalues greater than or equal to 1.00 (see Table 3). No item loaded less than .79 on its primary factor or greater than .29 on a secondary factor. Factor I was labeled "external assistance information," which described a network of contacts offering business related services and information to the owner. Factor II was labeled "external community information," which described a network of stakeholders not directly related to business operations. Factor III was labeled "competitor information," composed solely of contacts with competitors. Items with primary loadings on the same factor were summed and percentages of time spent in each BSA category were developed to form three dependent measures which represented each factor.

Table 3. Principal Components Factor Analysis of Boundary Spanning Items^a (Varimax Rotation)

Item	Factor I ^b	Factor II ^c	Factor III ^d
Business and Trade Associations	.98	.12	.07
Regulatory Agencies	.96	.10	.06
Private Consultants	.95	.08	.07
Bankers, Lawyers, Accountants	.88	.10	.15
Civic Organizations	-.05	.88	.15
Stockholders	.29	.79	-.12
Competitors	.16	.03	.97
Eigenvalue	3.79	1.30	1.00
% of Variance	63.1	21.6	13.6

^aItalicized items indicate items included in composite.

^bExternal Assistance Information.

^cExternal Community Information.

^dCompetitor Information.

A reliability check of the decision style items was performed employing the KR-20 formula for dichotomous data. For the information gathering dimension a reliability coefficient of .70 was obtained. The information processing dimension yielded a coefficient of .60 across the items. Given the small sample and the relatively large number of items contained in each dimension, these two reliability values were judged high enough to construct the primary decision style measure.

Grouping and Analytic Techniques. Each subject was grouped according to primary decision style which resulted in four groups of individuals being labeled as either SF (n = 20), ST (n = 7), NF (n = 24), or NT (n = 6). Because BSA was defined as multidimensional in nature and was composed of three separate dimensions, the primary analytic technique used was multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA). This test was run to determine if decision style affected total BSA. Given a significant overall F for the MANOVA test, several *post hoc* techniques were employed to investigate the specific nature of these differences. First, a multivariate extension of the Scheffe test was used to determine which decision style groups were different from each other across the combination of the three BSA variables. Second, the canonical discriminant loadings (the correlation of each BSA variable to the set of three BSA variables) for each dimension derived in the MANOVA analysis were reviewed. Third, centroids (a linear combination of the three BSA variables) were evaluated to determine which of the boundary spanning activities were preferred by each decision style. Finally, these procedures were followed up by a review of possible univariate differences between each decision style group on each of the three separate BSA variables.

RESULTS

Descriptive statistics showing the percentage of time spent on each BSA by group are included in Table 2. A significant MANOVA result was obtained ($p < .05$) indicating that decision style affects the BSA of the small business owner (see Table 4). This result supports the hypothesis that BSA will vary as a function of the small business owner's decision style. *Post hoc* analyses were conducted to understand the exact nature of this effect.

Table 4. Multivariate (MANOVA) and Univariate (ANOVA) Results of the Effect of Decision Style on Boundary Spanning Dimensions

Test	Value	Approx. F		df	Sig. of F	
Pillais	.300	1.96		9,159	.047	
VARIABLE	HYPOTH		ERROR		HYPOTH	
	SS	SS	MS	MS	Prob. ^a	
External Assistance Information	34896.83	206464.68	11632.28	3895.56		.039
Community Assistance Information	1206.12	19486.02	402.04	367.66		.360
Competitor Information	283.48	3106.66	94.49	58.62		.198

^adf = 3, 53 for each test.

Using a multivariate extension of the Scheffe test, significant differences were found between the NT-SF, NT-ST, and NT-NF decision styles ($p < .05$). These differences were interpreted by first looking at the canonical discriminant loadings underlying BSA dimensions and then reviewing group centroids for each dimension (see Table 5). Clearly, there are three distinct BSA dimensions which correspond to external assistance information, competitor information, and external community information respectively. Each of the items loaded highly on only one dimension with no primary loading being less than .98.

Table 5. Canonical Discriminant Analysis of the Underlying Boundary Spanning Structure

Correlations (Loadings) Between Canonical Discriminant Functions and Boundary Spanning Dimensions			
Boundary Spanning Variable	Function 1	Function 2	Function 3
External Assistance Information	.99	.10	.06
Competitor Information	.12	.08	.98
Community Information	.12	.99	.06

Canonical Discriminant Functions Evaluated at Group Centroids			
Group	Dimension 1	Dimension 2	Dimension 3
SF	-.15	-.22	.37
ST	-.19	.74	-.22
NF	-.11	-.06	-.16
NT	1.17	.12	-.32

An examination of the canonical discriminant functions evaluated at the group centroids indicated that the first dimension, representing external assistance information, is predominantly used by NTs; the second dimension, representing competitor information, is predominantly used by STs, and the third dimension, representing external community information, is used primarily by SFs (see Table 5). NFs did not utilize any one BSA dimension predominantly, suggesting that these small business owners engage in a variety of contacts. Notice in Table 5 almost exclusive usage of one BSA dimension over another for all decision style groups except NFs.

Following these multivariate analyses, univariate analyses of variance were conducted in order to determine the effect of decision style on each of the separate BSA dependent variables. Significant results were obtained for external assistance information ($p < .05$), indicating that individual decision style affects the selection of external assistance information (see Table 3). Results for the other two BSA variables were not significant.

Given the significant univariate results of decision style on external assistance information selection, a further examination of group differences was warranted. *Post hoc* analyses identified significant differences in external assistance information contacts ($p < .05$)

between NT - NF, NT - ST, and NT - SF groups. These results paralleled those obtained with the multivariate *post hoc* tests. No other mean comparisons were significant. In each of the above comparisons, the NTs spent more BSA time engaged in external assistance information contacts than any other decision style group.

DISCUSSION

The current investigation proposed to determine the effect of decision style on the BSA of small business owners. Given that the small business owner has to take responsibility for interfacing with external constituencies in order to maximize business performance as observed by Dollinger, it was hypothesized that decision style would affect the manner in which this interfacing took place (10, 11). As hypothesized, decision style was shown to affect BSA, as represented by the percentage of time spent on three categories of external information contacts.

The multivariate *post hoc* analyses revealed three dimensions related to decision styles. Owners with an NT style, based on general concepts and broad issue development, engaged in a greater number of contacts related to obtaining external assistance information than owners exhibiting any of the other four styles. These contacts include activities such as interacting with business and trade associations, regulatory agencies, private consultants, and bankers, lawyers, and accountants. Since NTs gather information on possibilities that is qualitative in nature, and process that information logically with formal reasoning, one might conclude that these contacts are for the purposes of facilitating the development and operations of their businesses.

Owners with an SF style, based on gathering hard facts and specific information with a human relations focus, engaged in external contact activities such as involvement in civic organizations and interaction with stockholders. The results suggest that the nature of these contacts is toward developing relationships and improving company image in the community.

Owners with an ST style, based on gathering factual data and logically analyzing it, focused on external activities related to developing information about competitors. This information might be used either to gain a competitive advantage or to monitor competitor activities in similar markets.

Owners with an NF style, represented by broad concerns of a social nature, did not employ a specific pattern of external contacts. These small business owners apparently used a variety of contacts across multiple categories. Overall, the relationships identified in this study between small business owner decision style and BSA are consistent with the scenario attributes developed by Nutt (19). Small business owners appear to be using boundary spanning activities consistent with their decision styles.

Although the study is limited by sample size and the region in which it was conducted, some tentative interpretations can be made. Similar to Barbato and Durlabhji's and Hoy and Hellriegel's discussions with respect to small business manager and entrepreneur decision styles, described below are some potential ways to improve the effectiveness of the boundary spanning activities of small business owners (4, 12),

First, it appears that small business owners may need to widen their focus to include gathering information with a broader external focus so that they do not overlook information important to the productivity of the firm as a result of primary information gathering and processing modes. NTs, whose primary focus was external assistance information, might want to develop contacts with competitors and establish networks within the community. SFs, whose primary focus was community information, would benefit from contacts with business and

trade associations, and competitors. In order to maximize boundary spanning, STs could supplement their competitor contacts with community and external business assistance constituencies. Given NFs' lack of any predominant BSA, they should determine if a broad focus or more specific BSA is appropriate for their enterprise.

This may be accomplished in several ways. For example, given the primary decision style and boundary spanning activities of the owner, consulting individuals who might solicit information from sources other than those preferred by the owner may add important input before critical decisions concerning firm operations are made. If feasible, the small business owner could seek out employees who complement the owner's decision style.

Second, Small Business Development Center counselors and Small Business Institute consultants should be aware of the constraints placed on the owner in terms of BSA. When consulting on a small business case, a review of the client's boundary spanning activities may identify where limitations currently exist in obtaining information needed by the firm. This review would act as a foundation to discuss strengths and weaknesses in the owner's search for and selection of external information.

Third, categorizing small business owners by decision style offers an opportunity to develop personal knowledge about one's own preferred style of dealing with information important to the firm. Counselors and consultants to small business owners and educators training future owners would benefit by using a decision style assessment as a means to develop an awareness on the part of the owner concerning how they made decisions (4, 12). Once primary decision style is identified, ways to supplement individual boundary spanning preferences may be developed.

Application of decision style theory to small business management offers a viable approach to investigate the manner in which small business owners make decisions affecting the performance, and ultimate success, of their enterprises. To build upon the current findings, research is necessary to more specifically determine the congruence between boundary spanning activities, owner's primary decision style, and effectiveness of the small firm. In addition, other external constituencies such as suppliers and vendors, potential new employees, customers and clients, and other owners/managers should be investigated to further delineate boundary spanning activities.

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About the Authors

Boundary Spanning Activity: A Function of Small Business Owner's Decision Style

Dr. James D. Brodzinski is an Associate Professor and Chairperson of the Department of Information and Decision Sciences at Salisbury State University in Maryland. His publications encompass the areas of information systems, entrepreneurship, statistics, and research methodology.

Dr. Robert F. Scherer is an Associate Professor and Chairperson of the Department of Management at Wright State University in Ohio. His research interests are in career development and entrepreneurship, areas in which he has published. His paper on entrepreneurial behavior received a TIEM Foundation "Award of Excellence" at the 1988 ICSB Conference.

Dr. Frank A. Wiebe is an Associate Professor of Management at the University of Mississippi. He has published in the areas of entrepreneurship and organizational behavior. He was co-recipient of a 1988 TIEM Foundation "Award of Excellence."

The Role of Locus of Control in Entrepreneurial Development and Success

Toby Kash is the Kelce Research Professor of Management at Pittsburg State University. He earned a Ph.D. from Michigan State University. His areas of interest in research are entrepreneurship, strategic management, and international business. He has written five books and about fifty articles and papers.

Dr. Richard K. Hay is Professor of Economics and Executive Director of the Institute for Economic Development at Pittsburg State University. He has extensive consulting experience and has presented papers at numerous national and international conferences. He has also published extensively in professional journals on both strategic management and entrepreneurship topics.

Michelle J. Carpenter, MBA, was formerly Director of the O. Gene Bicknell Center for Entrepreneurship at Pittsburg State University, Pittsburg, Kansas. Mrs. Carpenter is now Instructor of Management at Fort Hays State University, Hays, Kansas. Mrs. Carpenter has presented papers at numerous national and international conferences on management and entrepreneurship topics.

Human Resource Management in Small Business

Thomas J. Bergmann holds a Ph.D. from the Industrial Relations Center of the University of Minnesota. His primary interests include the areas of human resource management in both the public and private sectors. He has published in the *Journal of Occupational Psychology*, *Compensation Review*, *Personnel*, *Personnel Psychology*, *Personnel Administrator* and *Psychological Reports*.

Ronald Decker holds a Ph.D. in Marketing from the University of Iowa, Iowa City, Iowa. He is a former director of the University of Wisconsin-Eau Claire Small Business Development Center and is continually involved in small business consulting and programming.

Richard D. Lorentz holds a Ph.D. from the University of Northern Colorado in Management and Insurance. He is past President of the Small Business Institute Directors Association and has made several presentations at international, national, and regional small business conferences.

Business Incubators: Manager/Tenant Interaction Revisited

Daniel M. Spitzer, Jr., is Professor of Business Administration and chairman of the George S. Aldhizer II Department of Economics and Business at Bridgewater College in Bridgewater, VA. He holds a Ph.D. degree from the University of Virginia. His research interests lie in the areas of entrepreneurship, new product development, marketing research and marketing strategy.

Roger H. Ford is the Director of the Center for Entrepreneurship and an Assistant Professor of Management at James Madison University. He holds a Ph.D. from Syracuse University. Dr. Ford has published over forty articles, papers and book contributions in the areas of entrepreneurship, small business assistance and strategy, venture finance, business incubators, and boards of directors.

A Comparison of Entrepreneurs, Small Business Owners, Corporate Executives, and Public Sector Managers

Robert Anderson is a professor of policy and entrepreneurship. He is the co-author of two small business texts and several articles and cases about small business matters. Dr. Anderson is currently working on another small business textbook.